that the Chinese were building up their strength considerably. It was then estimated that between Tsona Dzong and Le, there were at least two regiments (equal to two Indian brigades) in the area. Even though reports of this build-up had been coming in for quite some time, Mullik was quite sure that the Chinese would not cross into Indian territory in large numbers. Mullik's assessment was that if the Chinese did escalate the border issue, there would only be some limited action by them in the Western Sector in the Chip Chap and Galwan valleys.

Mullik, who had the ear of both Menon and Nehru, had shrugged off remonstrations relating to the 'operational extravaganza unfolding on the Nam Ka Chu'. Instead the Intelligence chief had confirmed that it was indeed the Eastern Army Commander, Bogey Sen, who had assured the government of the operation's feasibility at the meeting of 12 September.

Thapar's directive to evict the Chinese across Thagla sent Army HQ into a tizzy. The massive logistical requirement for Dalvi's 7 Brigade was worked out on paper and all coordinating agencies—Air HQ, the railways, QMG's Branch, Eastern Command—got into the act. Dhillon himself took complete charge of the combined effort to support Eastern Command for Operation Leghorn. Movement of equipment and other stocks to Guwahati began almost immediately, while the daily airlift capability was increased from the existing 20 to 30 tons over the next few days. Eighty one-ton vehicles from the Ordnance Depot in Jabalpur were also dispatched during the week to increase the surface carrying capacity in NEFA.

The frenetic pace with which preparations for Operation Leghorn were being carried out in Army and Air HQs gave the impression that everything that could be done to equip Dalvi's brigade for the impending task was being done. The fact that almost half of the drops were ending in disaster because of faulty parachutes was not known at the time. Even when the parachutes did successfully deploy, loads would waft over the ridge at Lumpu and end up in the steep valleys below. The absence of worthwhile maps also meant that no one at Army HQ, including the DMO, Palit, had any idea of the ground conditions.

Lieutenant Colonel R. N. Mishra, the commanding officer of 9 Punjab, met Dalvi at Bridge 1 on the evening of 18 September. The battalion had preceded the brigade commander by a few days and had by then taken a good look around. The quarter-inch maps were based on the Captain Morshead survey and, as we have seen earlier, the Nam Ka Chu Valley had